

ART AND CULTURE



LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE

- LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT
- DRAVIDIAN LITERATURE

MODULE – 5



LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT

POST-VEDIC PERIOD

SANSKRIT



PALI



PRAKRIT



- 1 During the post-Vedic period, apart from Sanskrit, literature was also composed in Prakrit and Pali.

- 2 Prakrit is a term which is loosely attached to any language which deviated from the standard one, i.e. Sanskrit.

- 3 Pali is usually used to indicate the archaic or old form of Prakrit. In fact it is a combination of various dialects.

- 4 These languages gained prominence when religious literature of the Buddhists and Jains were composed in this language.

- 5 It is said that Lord Buddha used Pali to give his sermons and it is in the same language that they have been recorded.

LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT

Tripittaka - Three Baskets

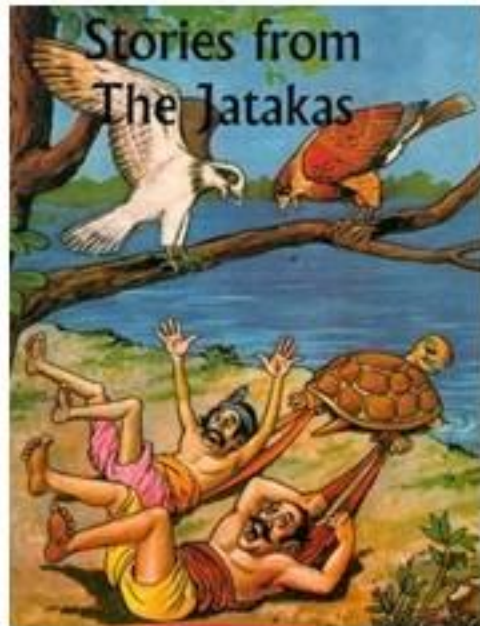


- 6 The Buddhist literature can be divided into **Canonical and Noncanonical works**.

- 7 The **Canonical literature** consists of '**Tripitikas**' or baskets (of knowledge).

- 8 The three Tripitakas are:
- **Vinaya Pitaka**, which covers the **rules and regulations**, which should be followed by the Buddhist monks.
 - The **Sutta Pitaka** contains dialogues and speeches of the Buddha that deal with **morality and righteous dharma**.
 - Lastly, the **Abhidhamma Pitaka** that concentrates on the philosophy and **metaphysics**. It also contains discussions on various topics like ethics, theory of knowledge and psychology.

LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT



- 9 The **Jatakas** are the best example of Buddhist non-canonical literature.

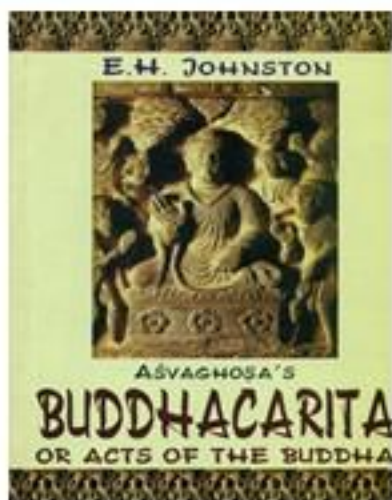
- 10 These are **compilation of the stories from the previous births of Buddha.**

- 11 The **stories of the Bodhisattva** or the (future) would-be Buddha are also discussed in these Jatakas.

- 12 These stories propagate Buddhist religious doctrines and they are available in **Sanskrit and Pali.**

- 13 Each story of the birth of the Buddha is equivalent to a Jataka tale.

LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT



- 14 It was believed that Buddha passed through 550 births before he was born as Gautama.
- 15 These tales combine the popular tales, ancient mythology as well as sociopolitical conditions in North India during those times.
- 16 The great epic *Buddhacharita* by *Aswaghosha* (78 A.D.) is another example of *Buddhist literature* in *Sanskrit*.

LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT



17 Another major religion, Jainism, produced texts in Prakrit.

18 The word Jain is derived from the root **ji (to conquer)** and signifies the religion of those who have conquered the lust for life.

19 Jain canonical literature by Jain saints, as well as a large number of **works on lexicography and grammar by Hemachandra** is well known.

20 Some of the Jain texts were also written in Sanskrit like the **Upamitibhava Prapancha Katha of Siddharasi** (906 A.D.).

21 The most important Jain texts written in Prakrit are the **Angas**, the **Upangas** and the **Prakirnakas**.

22 Apart from these the **Chheda Sutra** and the **Mulasutra** are also considered to be sacred by the Jains.

LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT

23 Amongst the secular writers attached to the Jains were Hemachandra who wrote a treatise on lexicography and grammar.

24 Mention could also be made of Haribhadra Suri who wrote in the eighth century.

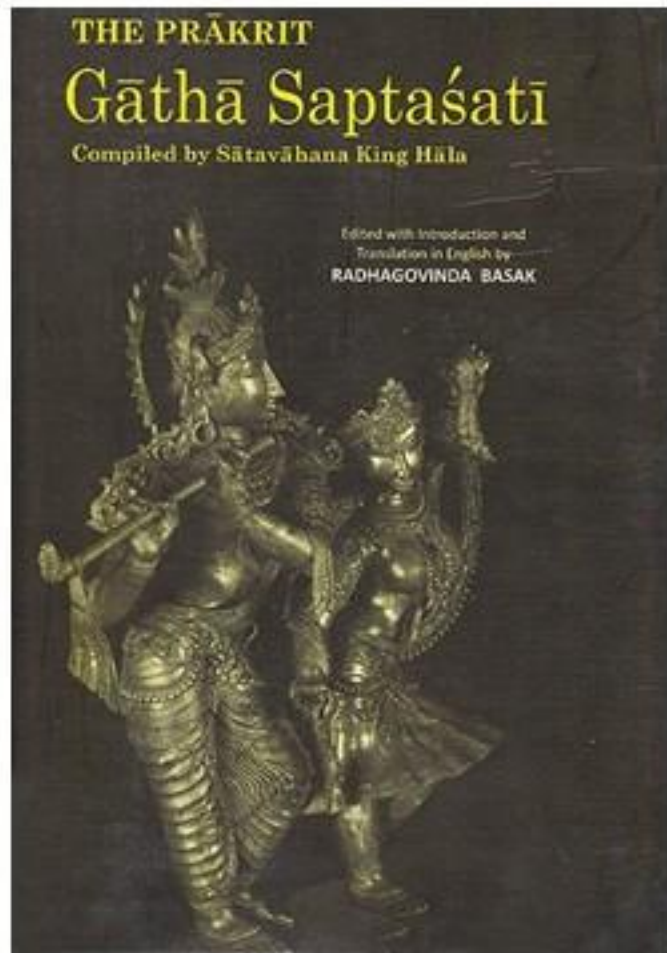
25 These treatises help us to expound on the sociopolitical history of areas densely populated by the Jaina community, which mostly comprised of traders.

26 Lastly, Prakrit literature has some elements of erotica through texts like the Gathasaptashati (700 verses) by Hala written in 300 A.D.

27 It is a compilation of 700 verses along with his own contribution of 44 poems.

28 It is interesting to note that quite a few poetesses like Pahai, Mahavi, Reva, Roha and Sasippaha are included in the anthology.

LITERATURE IN PALI AND PRAKRIT

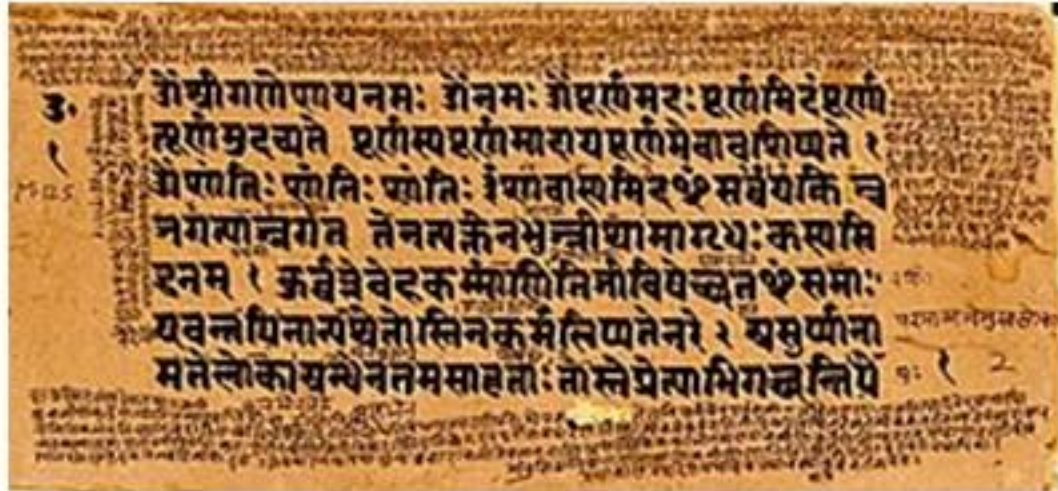


29 The vast Katha (story) literature of Prakrit, written with a conspicuous religious overtone, even by Jain saints, is full of erotic elements.

30 The author of the Vasudevahindi ascribes this changed approach of the Jain authors to the fact that it is easy to teach religion cloaked by erotic episodes, like sugar-coated medicine.

31 The characteristic of Prakrit poetry is its subtlety; the inner meaning (Hiyaali) is its soul.

ROLE OF SANSKRIT



- 1 It is one of the oldest recorded languages in the world and has been instrumental in **lending continuity to Indian/Vedic civilisation.**
- 2 Sanskrit has been the **mother of several Indo-Aryan languages** that draw heavily from its grammatical base and vocabulary.
- 3 Several texts written in Sanskrit like the **Dharamsastra** and the **Manusmriti** form the basis of many laws followed in our country even today.

REGIONAL LITERATURE



- 1 The regional literature of India is quite diverse and vast.
- 2 There are 22 scheduled languages and many other major languages, each of which has a rich literature with a history ranging from hundreds to thousands of years.
- 3 Here, a snapshot and salient elements of the prominent regional literatures are being captured.

LITERATURE OF INDIA

REGIONAL LITERATURE

DRAVIDIAN LITERATURE

- 1 This section comprises of literature in four major Dravidian languages: Tamil, Kannada, Telugu and Malayalam.



- 2 All these languages have borrowed many words from Sanskrit and vice versa.
- 3 Amongst these four languages Tamil is supposed to be the oldest and is the only modern Indian language which is recognizably continuous with a classical past.
- 4 The most famous literature in Tamil is the classical works or Sangam literature.

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE- AN INTRODUCTION

Pre-Nannaya Period

Age of Puranas

Age of Srinatha and
Prabhandas

Works of Krishnadevaraya

Modern Writers



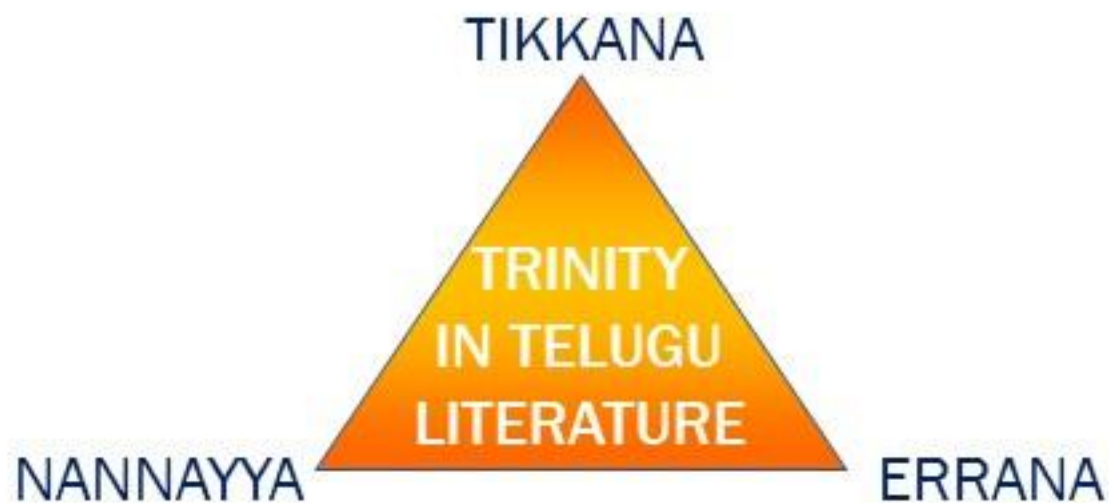
1 The earliest account of Telugu literature is noted in translation of Mahabharata in Telugu from Sanskrit by Nannaya.

2 Telugu literature was subsequently influenced by Lingayat movement (Virashaivism).

3 It flourished under the rule of the Vijayanagara Empire, where Telugu was one of the empire's official languages.

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE



- 1 In the earliest Pre-Nannaya period, Telugu literature existed in the form of **inscriptions**, precisely from 575 AD onwards.
- 2 The **age of Puranas** is the period of **Kavi Trayam** or **Trinity of Poets**.
- 3 **Nannayya, Tikkana and Yerrapragada** (or Errana) are known as the Kavi Trayam.
- 4 Kavitravam popularly refers to the poets who translated the great epic Mahabharata into Telugu.

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE

5 The **medieval period** of Telugu literature (14th and 15th century) is referred as the **age of Srinatha**.

6 Srinatha popularised the **Prabandha** style of composition.



6 Prabandha can be described as a story in verse form with a tight metrical structure. If one wishes to enjoy the richness of imagination, the unparalleled scholarship, the use of sweet and mellifluous words, and the grand ornate style of the Telugu poets, one has invariably to read the Prabandhas.

7 The Vijayanagara empire period (14th to 17th century) was the golden period of Telugu literature and it is said that **eight Telugu luminaries called the Ashtadiggajas** were a part of the king Krishnadevaraya's court.

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE

TENALI RAMAKRISHNA

1 He was popularly known as Tenali Rama and Vikata Kavi. He was court poet of the Vijayanagara empire and also said to be one of the Ashtadiggajas.



2 His famous work **Panduranga Mahatyam** is one among the **Pancha Kavyas**. He took the theme for Panduranga Mahatyam from the **Skanda Purana** and enhanced it with many stories about the **devotees of God Vitthala** (Panduranga).



PEDDANA

1 Allasani Peddana was ranked as the foremost of the Ashtadiggajalu the title for the group of eight poets in the court of Krishnadevaraya, a ruler of the Vijayanagara Empire.

2 He is revered as **Andhra Kavita Pitamaha** - "the grand father of Telugu poetry".

DHURJATI

1 Dhurjati or Dhoorjati was a poet in the court of Krishnadevaraya and was one of the 'Ashtadiggajalu'.

MAINS QUESTION

Qn

Krishnadeva Raya, the king of Vijayanagar, was not only an accomplished scholar himself but was also a great patron of learning and literature. Discuss.



WHY WAS IT ASKED?

- Krishnadeva Raya was in the news indirectly after the claim of a businessman that he is an incarnation of him.
- Also in cultural section, 'The Hindu' had given long article on Krishnadeva Raya.
- But the question asked by UPSC here is difficult as usually candidates prepare about Temple architecture of Vijayanagar empire or the administration.
- Here you had to discuss about the Vijayanagar literature in general and Krishnadeva Raya's writings in specific.

LITERATURE OF INDIA

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE

KRISHNADEVARAYA

WHAT IS HARIDASA MOVEMENT?

- This movement originated in Karnataka to spread the Dvaita philosophy of Madhavacharya.
- It later spread to Eastern States such as Bengal and Assam.
- This movement was ushered in by the Haridasas meaning “servants of Lord Hari”.
- It took shape in the 13th and 14th Century CE, during the rule of Vijayanagara empire.
- Prominent Hindu philosophers, poets and scholars such as Sripadaraya, Vyasathirtha, Vadirajatirtha, Purandara Dasa and Kanaka Dasa played an important role during this time.
- The Haridasa movement made significant contribution to Kannada devotional literature.

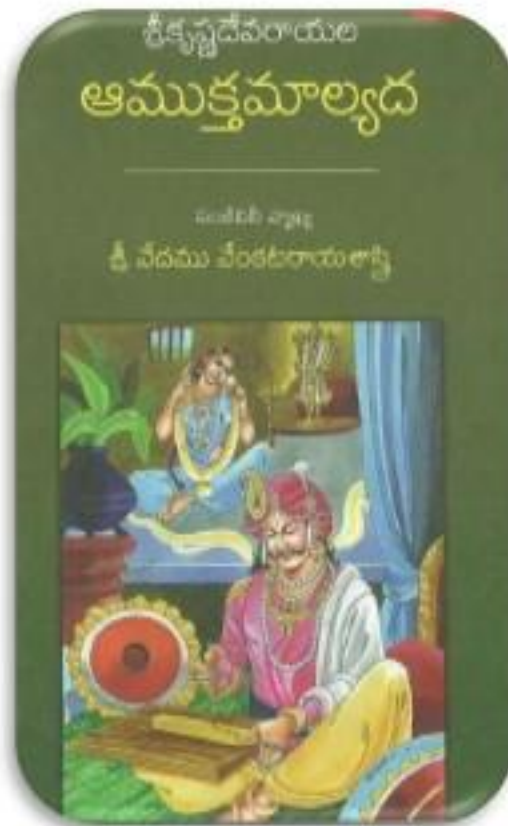
- Krishnadevaraya's reign marked a watershed in the cultural history of the medieval India.
- He presided over learned assemblies of pundits and poets, being an accredited writer in Telugu and Sanskrit, as also a patron of Kannada and Tamil literature.
- Sri Vyasaraya was his 'Raja Guru,' and during his reign, the Haridasa movement with Purandara, Kanaka and other leading lights composing 'Dasa Padagalu' in simple Kannada flourished.
- Scholarly works in Dvaita philosophy in both Kannada and Sanskrit authored.



REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE

KRISHNADEVARAYA



AMUKTAMALYADA

- Although Krishnadevaraya belonged to a Tulu family of Udipi whose presiding deity is Krishna, he founded a new era in Telugu literature.
- His own classical poetical composition in Telugu, 'Amuktha Malyada', is acclaimed as one of the "five literary gems" of Telugu literature.
- Krishna Deva Raya wrote the book Amuktamalyada in Telugu, describing the pangs of separation suffered by Andal (an incarnation of the goddess Mahalakshmi).
- He describes Andal's physical beauty in thirty verses; using descriptions of the spring and the monsoon as metaphors.
- As elsewhere in Indian poetry, the sensual pleasure of union extends beyond the physical level and becomes a path to, and a metaphor for, spirituality and ultimate union with the divine.

LITERATURE OF INDIA

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE

KRISHNADEVARAYA



- Till Krishnadevaraya's time, Telugu literature comprised of mere Telugu versions of Ramayana and Mahabharata.
- The king encouraged original poems.
- Thus Krishnadevaraya did earn the well deserved distinction of 'Raja Bhoja' of the South.
- His court like that of Bhoja's was resplendent with a galaxy of eight premier Telugu poets.

LITERATURE OF INDIA

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE



1 In the modern period, **K. Viresalingam Pantulu** is considered as the Father of Telugu literature and credited to have written over a 100 books.

2 He also played a prominent role in the **development of Telugu Journalism**.

VEERASALINGAM PANTULU

3 He was influenced by the ideals of Brahmo Samaj particularly those of **Keshub Chunder Sen**.

4 He was one of the early social reformers who encouraged **women education, remarriage of widows** which was not supported by the society during his time and fought against dowry system.

5 He is often considered as **Raja Rammohan Roy of Andhra**. He was also known by the title **Gadya Tikkana**, meaning 'Tikkana of Prose'.

REGIONAL LITERATURE

TELUGU LITERATURE



Ravuri Bharadwaja

6

Other important Litterateurs of modern Telugu:

- R. Subba Rao (poet),
- G. Appa Rao (poet),
- K. Venkateswara Rao,
- **Vishwanatha Satyanarayan** (Sahitya Akademi, Jnanpith and Padma Bhushan awardee),
- **C. Narayan Reddy** (Jnanpith and Padma Bhushan Awardee) and
- **Ravuri Bharadwaja** (Sahitya Akademi and Jnanpith Awardee)

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